ceded by a vast nameless and authorless compendium of knowledge, closely knit and guarded in cryptic lines safe and suitable for oral transmission from generation to generation. The first task, therefore, of early Indian thinkers was to interpret, explain, and coordinate this vast body of knowledge inherited and preserved by tradition rather than to function in a vacuum. This often gives to an outside observer the impression that rational thinking in India is authority-ridden or is nothing more than an interpretation of what is believed to have been already accepted as true, and that there is no original and free rational thinking beyond the spere of the already given. This is not true, however, for, as will be shown later, while Indian philosophy is also by historical circumstances interpretative, in philosophical contribution, it is no less original or daring than any other. It is not wrong, however, for intellect and reasoning to function in relation to a traditional heritage, the beginnings of which, at least in the case of India, are absolutely unknown.

Second, there is a philosophical fact of infinitely greater importance which follows from the above. Psychologically, knowing itself is defined and understood in India as necessarily involving the three steps of *śravaṇa* (hearing), *manana* (examination of what is heard), and *nididhyāsana* (realization or assimilation of what is thus reflected upon). That the first step in knowing is called *hearing* and not *perceiving* shows the verbal character of early knowledge. If an individual or an age has such a thing as tradition preceding it, one learns first by hearing. If, however, one is devoid of all tradition and has nothing to precede one's own thinking, one must look and see for oneself. But as most knowledge is first acquired by hearing from those who know more, verbal testimony is the inevitable relationship between what is learned and the source of learning. But uncritical acceptance of what is given on testimony is never expected, and that is why *manana* or a critical examination by one's own reason of what is thus learned is invariably recommended as a necessary and a prior step to the final realization of truth on the part of a seeker of true knowledge. It is, therefore, this Indian emphasis on testimony (due to the existence of traditional wisdom) as the inevitable first step of all knowledge that is also sometimes misunderstood in the West as being synonymous with truth itself in Indian philosophy, because the second and the third steps of critical reflection and final assimilation are largely lost sight of.

To begin with, therefore, we should clear up a misunderstanding which exists widely in the West with regard to the logical status